nestled in a valley of vineyards in Muddenahalli, a short drive from Bengaluru airport, in Karnataka's Chikkaballapur district, is poised to become a holy hub rivalling Prasanthi Nilayam, where the late guru had lived and died. The pivot of Muddenahalli's Sathya Sai Grama is no ordinary pulpit preacher. Following in the footsteps of his spiritual master, Madhusudan has been able to cultivate a charismatic image. He may not have the curly mop of hair that his guru had, but with a crew cut, a clean-shaven look, a forever affable expression on his face, and shiny saffron silk robe, he has a distinctive persona of his own.

However, it's not from appearance alone that Madhusudhan derives his legitimacy. It is also drawn from his late guru's statements such as "My students are my property" and the agents of change who would make his dream of a new world of harmony, peace, acceptance, service and love come true. Shashidhar Prasad, a former vice-chancellor of the University of Mysuru and SSSIHL, ascribes the rapid growth of Sathya Sai Grama to Madhusudan's mystical powers. "Swami (Sri Sathya Sai Baba) told me that he would spend the last part of his life in the hilltop building at Sathya Sai Grama in Muddenahalli. One day, when I was asked to meet brother Madhusudan there, I was amazed that he revealed many things about my interactions with Swami that were highly personal," says Prasad. It is anecdotes like these that have served to strengthen Madhusudhan's claim on Sathya Sai Baba's legacy.

Muddenahalli's connection to Sri Sathya Sai Baba and Puttaparthi goes back five decades. It was here that an ardent devotee, Madiyal Narayan Bhat, set up the Satya Sai Grama (SSG) after he met Sai Baba in 1962. A residential school for boys was founded in 1972 and, a few years later, a pre-university college. Until a decade ago, these were the only buildings at SSG apart from the community hall where Sri Sathya Sai Baba would give darshan while travelling between his ashrams at Puttaparthi and Whitefield in Bengaluru.

PUPIL'S PROGRESS



ALMA MATER First convocation of the Sri Sathya Sai University for Human Excellence, Kalaburagi, Karnataka

Given his middle-class moorings in the BALCO township in Chhattisgarh, Madhusudan Naidu realised early that hard work is the passport to success. After moving to Puttaparthi, he made the most of the opportunity while studying at the Sri Sathya Sai Institute of Higher Learning (SSSIHL). There, he bagged a gold medal in BSc (Chemistry) in 1999, an outstanding grade in MSc (Chemistry) in 2001 and another gold medal in MBA (2003). During these years, the young Madhusudan observed and picked up Sathya Sai Baba's traits.

After his MBA, he did a stint with the HDFC Bank between 2003 and 2009, and ran a financial advisory firm in Bengaluru from 2009 to 2011. Following Sathya Sai's demise in 2011, he joined hands with B.N. Narasimha Murthy, a former SSSIHL hostel warden, and decided to take his mission forward by breaking away from Prasanthi Nilayam. Along with C. Sreenivas, who was associated with Sathya Sai's healthcare mission, and Isaac Tigrett of Hard Rock Café fame, who was among those who funded the mission's first superspeciality hospital, they claim to have come together at the late guru's behest to build new institutions. Though the Prasanthi Nilayam establishment has rejected Madhusudan, this has not deterred his devotees. "I knew Madhusudan as a student and Narasimha Murthy as a hostel warden," says A. Anantharaman, a former SSSIHL faculty member. "Brilliant as they were in their roles at Prasanthi Nilayam, I cannot believe their human capabilities could create the structure at Muddenahalli and ensure exponential expansion without some spiritual power."

At Sathya Sai Grama, chanting of prayers and singing of bhajans are part of the daily routine just like they are at Prasanthi Nilayam. Madhusudan gives a religious discourse on Thursdays and Sundays. He lives in a two-storeyed building designed like a temple, with a prayer hall on the ground floor and his personal quarters above it. Though he has positioned himself as Sathya Sai's spiritual successor, some are sceptical about his devotional quotient. Sceptics say his devotional activity does not have the same traction as that of Sathya Sai, though several senior devotees go to Muddenahalli now because of what is being done in the areas of healthcare and education.